worlds, and went far: as far, eventually, as Patagonia – and as far, eventually, as the moon.

It is not against nature to be curious: it is in our nature to be so.

One hundred thousand years ago our species left Africa, compelled perhaps by precisely this curiosity, learning to look ever further afield. Flying over Africa by night, I wondered if one of these distant ancestors setting out towards the wide open spaces of the North could have looked up into the sky and imagined a distant descendant flying up there, pondering on the nature of things, and still driven by the very same curiosity.

I believe that our species will not last long. It does not seem to be made of the stuff that has allowed the turtle, for example, to continue to exist more or less unchanged for hundreds of millions of years; for hundreds of times longer, that is, than we have even been in existence. We belong to a short-lived genus of species. All of our cousins are already extinct. What's more, we do damage. The brutal climate and environmental changes which we have triggered are unlikely to spare us. For the Earth they may turn out to be a small irrelevant blip, but I do not think that we will outlast them unscathed – especially since public and political opinion prefers to ignore the dangers which we are running, hiding our heads in the sand. We are perhaps the only species on Earth to be conscious of the inevitability of our individual mortality. I fear that soon we shall also have to become the only species that will knowingly watch the coming of its own collective demise, or at least the demise of its civilization.

As we know more or less well how to deal with our individual mortality, so we will deal with the collapse of our civilization. It is not so different. And it's certainly not the first time that this will have happened. The Maya and Cretans, amongst many others, have already experienced this. We are born and die as the stars are born and die, both individually and collectively. This is our reality. Life is precious to us because it is ephemeral. And as Lucretius wrote: 'our appetite for life is voracious, our thirst for life insatiable' (*De rerum natura*, III, 1084). But immersed in this nature which made us and which directs us, we are not homeless beings suspended between two worlds, parts *of* but only partly belonging *to* nature, with a longing for something else. No: we are home.

Nature is our home, and in nature we are *at* home. This strange, multicoloured and astonishing world which we explore – where space is granular, time does